

Is Social Work Safe From AI? The 2026 Degree Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

3.3

AI EXPOSURE · CHILD PROTECTION

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.



Quick answer: Child protection social work scores **3.3 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk. Adult safeguarding and community social work scores **3.8**. Case management and assessment coordination scores **6.1**. Social work is protected by something rarer than a license: statutory authority to act on another person's life.

The short answer for parents: yes on AI exposure, and the reasons people leave social work have nothing to do with technology. Caseloads, under-resourcing and public criticism are the real risks here, and they are worse than the automation risk by a wide margin.

Social work AI risk score by field

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a social worker and a paralegal.

FIELD	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
Child protection	2.7	3.0	3.3	+0.6	Low
Mental health social work	3.2	3.4	3.7	+0.5	Low
Adult safeguarding / community	3.3	3.6	3.8	+0.5	Low
Hospital / medical social work	3.3	3.6	3.9	+0.6	Low–Moderate
Case management / assessment coordination	5.3	5.7	6.1	+0.8	Moderate–High

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Licensed clinical psychology scores **3.5**. Classroom teaching scores **3.6**. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**.

The gap between frontline practice and coordination roles is 2.8 points, and it falls exactly where you would expect: on whether the worker has the authority to decide something.

Will AI replace social workers?

Not the practice. It is taking a large share of the paperwork, which is the single biggest complaint in the profession.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Case notes and report writing	Judging whether a child is safe
Form completion and referrals	Being trusted by a family that fears you
Records summarization and chronologies	Sitting with someone in crisis
Meeting minutes and documentation	Statutory authority to act
Resource and eligibility lookup	Accountability when a decision goes wrong
Scheduling and caseload administration	Reading a home, a room, a relationship

Social workers routinely report spending more time on documentation than on people. Automating that layer is unambiguously good news for the profession — and it is happening.

Why does social work score low? The six factors

How adult safeguarding and community social work rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	6.1	↑ moderate exposure
How hard will it be to land that first job?	3.5	↓ good protection
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	6.0	↓ moderate protection
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	9.0	↓ strong protection
Does the law require a licensed human?	7.5	↓ good protection
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	8.5	↓ strong protection

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.

Does the law require a licensed human? — rated 7.5, and social work has something stronger than a license

Most licensed professions in this index are protected by a *restriction*: only a qualified person may perform this activity. Only a CPA may sign the audit. Only a pharmacist may dispense. Only a barred attorney may appear in court.

Social work has that, and it also has something we score in only a handful of careers: **statutory authority to act on another person's life without their consent**.

A social worker can initiate proceedings to remove a child from a family. They can trigger safeguarding measures for an adult who cannot protect themselves. They contribute to decisions that end with someone losing their liberty or their children. These are among the gravest powers any professional holds, and they are conferred on a registered human being by legislation.

This is a different kind of protection from ordinary licensing, and it is more durable. A restriction on who may perform a task could, in principle, be relaxed if the technology became good enough and the political will existed — professions lose scope-of-practice protections occasionally. But the authority to intervene coercively in a family's life sits on a foundation of democratic legitimacy and human accountability that has no plausible route to being delegated to a system. A society that would accept an algorithm removing a child is not one that would be reasoning about efficiency.

Watch what happens when that authority is absent. Case management and assessment coordination roles — genuinely social-work-adjacent, often held by qualified people — rate 5.0

on this factor and score 6.1. They gather information, apply eligibility criteria and coordinate services. No coercive authority, no irreducible human requirement, and a score more than two points higher.

The general lesson: distinguish between licenses that restrict a task and authority that requires a person. The first is protection that can erode. The second is protection that would require a change in what a society is willing to delegate — and those change far more slowly than technology does.

Which social work careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Child protection — 3.3.** The gravest statutory authority, maximum trust requirement, and continuous novelty. 2. **Mental health social work — 3.7.** Deep relational work with real risk judgment. 3. **Adult safeguarding / community — 3.8.** Statutory duties in unpredictable home settings. 4. **Hospital / medical social work — 3.9.** Coordination-heavy, but with genuine advocacy and discharge risk decisions. 5. **Case management / assessment coordination — 6.1.** Eligibility and coordination work, without the authority that protects the rest.

Is social work a good career in 2026?

The AI question is comfortably settled. The honest answer is that this profession's problems are severe and entirely non-technological.

Caseloads are routinely above what is manageable, which is the top complaint and largely outside any individual's control. Under-resourcing is chronic in most systems. Public criticism when cases go wrong is severe and often unfair, and it lands on individuals who were carrying impossible workloads.

The emotional weight is sustained rather than episodic. This is work with people in genuine crisis, repeatedly, over years.

Against that: practitioners describe an unusually strong sense of purpose, enormous variety of settings, and genuine advocacy for people who have very few advocates. Entry is comparatively accessible, and the qualification is portable across settings.

AI is, in this case, straightforwardly good news — it is taking the paperwork burden that people cite when they leave. Whether that translates into manageable caseloads or simply more

cases per worker is the question worth watching, and it will be decided by funding rather than technology.

Common questions

Will AI replace social workers? No. Statutory authority to intervene in someone's life is conferred on a registered human, and the judgment involved is precisely the kind AI handles worst.

Is social work a good degree? On exposure, yes — 3.8 for community practice against a median of about 5.5. The difficulties are caseloads and resourcing rather than automation.

What social work roles are safest from AI? Child protection at 3.3, then mental health social work at 3.7. Both carry statutory authority and high-stakes judgment.

Is social work safer than psychology? Comparable — social work 3.8 against licensed clinical psychology 3.5. Social work reaches practice considerably faster; psychology requires graduate training and supervised hours.

Will AI reduce social work paperwork? It already is, and it is the clearest benefit of AI in any profession we score. Whether that time returns to practice or is absorbed by higher caseloads depends on funding decisions rather than the technology.

Related profiles

- **Psychology** — 3.5 licensed clinical, 7.1 with the degree alone
 - **Nursing** — 2.8 bedside, 5.4 desk-based
 - **Teaching** — 3.6 classroom, 6.8 online
 - **Law** — 7.9 junior associate, 4.5 trial advocacy
 - **Business and management** — 7.6 analyst, 4.9 leadership
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What's in the full social work profile

This sampler tells you where social work stands. The full profile tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	FULL PROFILE
Verdict, all field scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is		✓
The honest downsides — caseloads, resourcing, public criticism, emotional load		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Routes in — undergraduate, graduate conversion, and registration		✓
Where it leads later — specialization, management, policy, therapy		✓
Program evaluation checklist — placement quality, specialisms, support		✓
Questions to ask a program — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

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Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.